Pink

By Judith Thompson

INTRODUCTION

In 1970s South Africa, 10-year-old Lucy's black nanny is killed during a peaceful protest march. The insidious nature of racism is put on full display as the child attempts to convince the nanny's spirit that apartheid is good for her people. Pink by Judith Thompson

LUCY, *a 10-year-old white girl talking to her dead black nurse, Nellie, shot in a march, in her open coffin.*

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LUCY: NELLIE I want you to come back, to shampoo my hair and make a pink cake and we can sit in the back and roll mealie pap in our hands see, I told you not to go in those marches and I told you, I told you that what you guys don't understand, what you didn't see, is apartheid's for YOU. IT'S FOR YOUR GUYS' FEELINGS, see, like we got separate washrooms cause you like to spit, and if we said, Eww yucch, don't spit, it would hurt your feelings and we got separate movies, cause you like to talk back to movie stars and say amen and that's the way and stuff and that drives us crazy so we might tell you to shut up and then you might cry and we got separate bus stops cause you don't like deodorant cause you say it smells worse than people and we might tell you you stink and the only thing I don't get is how come you get paid less for the same job my Mummy says it's because you people don't like money anyway, you don't like TVs and

stereos and all that stuff cause what you really like to do is sing and dance. And you don't need money to sing and dance I just … I don't understand why you weren't happy with us, Mummy let you eat as much sugar as you wanted, and we never said anything to you, some days, Mummy says it was up to a quarter-pound, but we know blacks like sugar so we didn't mind, and we even let you take a silver spoon, I heard Mummy say to her friends, there goes another silver spoon to Soweto but she never called the police...

… and you had your own little room back there, and we even let your husband come once in a while, and that's against the law, Mummy and Daddy could have gone to jail for that, so how come you weren't grateful? How come you stopped singing those Zulu songs in the morning, those pretty songs like the one that was about love and kissing, you stopped singing, and you stopped shampooing my hair, you said I could do it myself, and and your eyes, your eyes used to look at me when I was little they would look at me like they were tickling me just tickling me all the time, like I was special, but they went out, they went out like a light does and you stopped making my cakes every Tuesday, every Tuesday morning I would ask you to make me a pink cake and you would always say, you ask your mummy and then you'd make it, but you stopped making them, you told me I was too old for pink cakes, that the pink wasn't real, it was just food colour anyway and then, and then, you hardly ever came anymore, and when I saw you that day … when I saw you downtown with your husband and four children all … hanging off your arms, I just couldn't stand it! I wanted to yell at your children and tell them you were mine that you were more mine than theirs because you were with me

more much more so you were mine and to let go of you to get off you and I hated the way you looked without your uniform, so brown and plain, not neat and nice anymore, you looked so pretty in your uniform, so pretty, but we didn't even mind when you didn't want to wear it.

We didn't mind, but you were still unhappy, and when I saw you in town looking so dusty and you didn't even introduce me to your kids and one of them, one of them did that rude thing that 'Amandilia' thing that means black power I saw you slap his hand but you didn't say anything, so you must have hated me too, I saw that you hated me too and I'd been so nice to you, I told you my nightmares and you changed my bed when I wet it and now you didn't even like me and it wasn't my fault it wasn't my fault it just when I asked you why that day, you were cleaning the stove and I said Nellie why … don't you like me anymore, and you said, you're not a child anymore, Lucy, you're a white person now and it wasn't my fault I couldn't help it I couldn't help yelling

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SLAVE, SLAVE, DO WHAT YOU'RE TOLD, SLAVE OR I SLAP YOUR BLACK FACE, I SLAP YOUR BLACK FACE AND I KICK YOUR BLACK BELLY I KICK YOUR BLACK BELLY AND KICK IT TILL IT CAVES RIGHT IN AND IT CAN'T HOLD MORE BABIES EVER AGAIN. NO MORE UGLY BLACK BABIES THAT YOU'LL … that you'll like more than me. Even though I'm ten years old I made you die. I made you go in that march and I made you die. I know that forever. I said I was sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm

sorry, but you never looked at me again. You hated me. But I love you, Nellie, more than Mummy or Daddy and I want you to come back, and sing those songs, and roll mealie pap and be washing the floor in your nice uniform so I can come in and ask you to make a pink cake and your eyes will tickle me. And you will say yes.

Yes, I'll make a pink cake …

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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